



**RANNA GILL** Autumn Garden, a Contemporary collection, embodies the transition from summer to winter.

**"Luxurious and lustrous fabrics like heavy silk, brocade and staple jersey add a sense of lyrical drama."**

**SUNEET VERMA** Lure of the Orient, a Contemporary line, is inspired by Colonial influences in South East Asia.

**"Cavalry elements like sharp jackets and applets combine with soft shirts and dresses."**

prepare for their catwalk call. Even as designers sharpen their couture cutlasses and fashionistas polish their Louboutin stilettos, the battle lines are drawn in the style sweepstakes.

As the Fashion Design Council of India's (FDCI) forces strengthen, trends also signal the return of military silhouettes, strong shoulders, straight lines and simple cuts ready to jump into combat. But this time the war cry is distinctly different with luxury promising a winter of extravagance. While global ramp romps bandy terms like luxury, indulgence and sumptuous on cue sheets, FDCI's mantra this

season is 'divide and rule'. The colonial diktat might not be politically correct but India's fashion fraternity is taking a directive from it. This season will see the couture community indulge in a healthy dose of group-ism as designers will showcase collections under the Heritage/Synthesis, Contemporary and Creator categories. Taking a leaf from events on the international fash-

ion calendar, desi designers will be divided on the basis of the nature of their collections. "In all our interactions with buyers and trade persons, including the media, the one thing that emerged was that the event needed more focus. And since India is in a unique position where we have Western as well as indigenous clothing, we decided to create groups and let the designers categorise themselves," says Sumeet Nair, executive director, FDCI. Designers showcasing under Synthesis will merge Indian sensibilities with international ethos, while those under Contemporary will incorporate ultra prêt clothing of international standards and Creator will allow the designer room to be original.

The designer lobby, though unsure of exact implications, is looking at the new development with guarded optimism. While veterans like Valaya prefer to wait and watch, Varun Bahl is more optimistic. "I think it's great because buyers will know

